

Far-Western Nepalese Society Maryland, USA

Established 2019 • Incorporated July 15, 2022 • 501(c)(3) Public Charity
EIN: 93-2746265

B Y L A W S

Adopted at the Annual General Meeting held on February 28, 2026

Far-Western Nepalese Society, Maryland, USA

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Article I. Name

The organization shall be named the Far-Western Nepalese Society, Maryland, USA (hereinafter “FWNS-MD” or “the Society”). It is a nonprofit corporation incorporated under the laws of the State of Maryland and recognized as a tax-exempt public charity under Section 501(c)(3) of the Internal Revenue Code.

Article II. Principal Address

The principal address of the Society shall be the current residence or place of business of the serving President. The incoming President shall update the Society’s official address upon assuming office.

As of the date of adoption of these Bylaws, the principal address is:

[Address on file with the General Secretary]

The Executive Committee shall notify relevant government agencies, the IRS, and the Society’s bank(s) of any change of address within thirty (30) days of a new President assuming office. No amendment to these Bylaws is required to update the principal address.

Article III. Purposes

The Far-Western Nepalese Society of Maryland is a community-driven nonprofit organization. Its purposes are exclusively charitable, educational, cultural, and civic in nature, and include:

Community & Cultural Preservation

- Preserve, promote, and celebrate the rich cultural heritage, language, traditions, and festivals of the Far-Western region of Nepal among members and the broader Maryland community.
- Organize cultural events, festivals, performances, and community gatherings that strengthen the identity and pride of Far-Western Nepali Americans.
- Foster relationships with other Nepali and South Asian organizations across the United States and internationally.

Youth, Education & Next-Generation Engagement

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- Actively engage children and youth of the Nepali diaspora in volunteer activities, sports programs, cultural education, and community service.
- Provide scholarships, mentorship, and educational support to students of Nepali heritage in Maryland.
- Create opportunities for the next generation to connect with their cultural roots while thriving as American citizens.
- Organize youth sports leagues, recreational programs, and community-building activities that promote teamwork, leadership, and healthy lifestyles.

Civic Engagement & Advocacy

- Promote and foster relationships with local, state, and federal levels of government on behalf of the Nepali American community.
- Advocate for the civil rights, civic participation, and public representation of Nepali Americans in Maryland.
- Educate members on civic duties including voter registration, community involvement, and public policy.

Humanitarian & Charitable Work

- Raise funds and mobilize community resources to assist victims of natural or man-made disasters, both in the United States and in Nepal.
- Provide financial and emotional support to community members facing hardship due to illness, death, or other emergencies.
- Support Human Rights and Civil Liberties initiatives and assist victims of violations in Nepal and the USA.

Nonprofit Development & Organizational Growth

- Build and sustain a transparent, well-governed nonprofit organization that serves as a model for community-based organizations in the Maryland area.
- Develop partnerships with other nonprofits, businesses, and institutions to expand the Society's impact and services.
- Pursue grants, donations, and fundraising activities in accordance with applicable laws to fund the Society's programs and operations.

Article IV. Membership

Membership in the Society is open to individuals who are supportive of the Far-Western Nepali community and the mission and values of FWNS-MD. The Society particularly

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serves and represents the Far-Western Nepali community of Maryland, and its programs and priorities reflect that community's interests. All membership applications are subject to approval as described below. There are three (3) active membership categories:

A. General Membership

Any individual who demonstrates a sincere interest in supporting the Society's mission and the Far-Western Nepali community may apply for General Membership. To qualify, the applicant must:

- Complete a Membership Application and pay the applicable dues; and
- Demonstrate meaningful community involvement by having attended at least one (1) FWNS-MD event, OR by being vouched for by one (1) existing member in good standing.

General Member applications are reviewed and approved by the General Secretary on behalf of the Executive Committee. The General Secretary may refer any application to the full Executive Committee for review if deemed necessary. Dues are as follows:

- Individual General Member: \$25.00 per year
- Couple / Family General Member: \$50.00 per year (carries two votes)

General membership is valid for a two (2) year term concurrent with the serving Executive Committee term. General Members are entitled to vote at all General Assembly meetings and elections, provided they meet the eligibility requirements in Article X. General Members are not eligible to run as candidates for any elected position on the Executive Committee.

B. Life Membership (Individual)

Individual Life Membership recognizes a deeper, long-term commitment to the Society. To be eligible, an applicant must:

- Have been an active General Member of FWNS-MD in good standing for at least one (1) continuous year prior to applying; and
- Have attended at least two (2) FWNS-MD events during that membership year, demonstrating meaningful involvement with the community; and
- Submit a Life Membership application, which must be approved by a majority vote of the Executive Committee.

Individual Life Membership requires a one-time payment of \$100.00. Life Members have full voting rights in all General Assembly matters and elections. Life Members are eligible

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to run for at-large Board of Directors positions on the Executive Committee immediately upon approval. To run for the five (5) core officer positions — President, Vice President, General Secretary, Secretary, or Treasurer — a Life Member must have held Life Member status for at least one (1) year, resulting in a minimum total community involvement period of two (2) years before assuming a core leadership role.

C. Couple Life Membership

Two individuals in a household may jointly apply for Couple Life Membership. Each individual must independently meet the same eligibility requirements as Individual Life Membership:

- Each applicant must have been an active General Member for at least one (1) continuous year; and
- Each applicant must have attended at least two (2) FWNS-MD events during that membership year; and
- The joint application must be approved by a majority vote of the Executive Committee.

Couple Life Membership requires a one-time payment of \$150.00. Both individuals hold full voting rights and are eligible to run for at-large Board positions immediately, or for the five (5) core officer positions after holding Life Member status for at least one (1) year.

D. Membership Eligibility Summary

The following table summarizes the eligibility pipeline for membership and leadership:

- **General Member:** Apply + 1 FWNS event or 1 member voucher + General Secretary approval → Vote at General Assembly
- **Life Member:** 1 year as General Member + 2 FWNS events + EC majority approval → Vote + run for at-large Board positions
- **Core Officer (President, VP, General Secretary, Secretary, Treasurer):** Life Member for 1+ year → Minimum 2 years total involvement before running

E. Discontinued Membership Categories & Transition

Effective as of the Annual General Meeting held on February 28, 2026, the Student General (\$10) and Senior Citizen (\$10) membership categories have been discontinued. Former members who held these categories must renew their membership under one of the three active categories above to retain their membership standing and voting rights.

- **Former Student Members:** encouraged to renew as General Members (\$25 individual).

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- Former Senior Citizen Members: encouraged to renew as General Members (\$25 individual) or Life Members (\$100) as appropriate.

The Executive Committee may, at its discretion, offer a transitional renewal grace period of up to ninety (90) days from the date of adoption of these Bylaws to allow former members to renew without losing continuity of membership.

F. Honorary Recognition

Persons who have made a substantial contribution to the growth of FWNS-MD, or who have distinguished themselves in ways that bring honor to the Nepali community, may be nominated for Honorary Recognition by the Executive Committee and ratified by a majority of the General Assembly. Honorary recognition carries no voting rights and confers no eligibility to run for office.

G. Membership Dispute Resolution

In the event of any dispute regarding membership status, membership recognition, or membership classification — including but not limited to disputes involving pre-registration memberships, Life Member recognition, or legacy membership claims — the serving President of the Far-Western Nepalese Society of Maryland shall have the final authority to review, adjudicate, and resolve the dispute. The President's decision on any membership dispute shall be final and binding, subject only to appeal by a two-thirds (2/3) majority vote of the full Executive Committee.

Members who held Life Membership status prior to the official state registration of FWNS-MD and whose membership has not been formally recognized shall be entitled to submit a written request to the President for recognition. The President shall review such requests and may grant formal Life Member recognition after consultation with the Executive Committee.

Article V. Executive Committee

A. Composition

The Executive Committee shall consist of fifteen (15) members, comprising the following elected officers and directors:

- President
- Vice President

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- General Secretary
- Secretary
- Treasurer
- Ten (10) Members at Large (Board of Directors)

Of the fifteen (15) positions, up to three (3) members at large may be nominated and appointed by the elected Executive Committee rather than elected at the General Assembly, provided the nominations are ratified by a majority of the General Assembly. All Executive Committee members serve on a voluntary basis and receive no compensation. Members are eligible for re-election for one additional consecutive term.

B. Gender Inclusion Requirement

At least thirty-three percent (33%) of the total elected positions on the Executive Committee shall be held by women. The Election Committee shall ensure that the candidate roster and final election results reflect this requirement. If, following an election, fewer than 33% of filled positions are held by women, the Executive Committee shall take corrective measures as determined by the General Assembly, which may include appointing qualified women members to vacant at-large seats until the threshold is met.

C. Duties of the Executive Committee

The Executive Committee shall have authority to implement decisions and programs approved by the General Assembly, and to take any actions that promote the purposes and fulfill the objectives of the Society. A majority of the committee shall constitute a quorum, and a majority of those present shall decide issues. Written letters and emails shall be valid for quorum and proxy voting purposes.

D. Executive Committee Meetings

The Executive Committee shall meet at least once each quarter, or more frequently as called by the President.

E. Subcommittees

For special occasions, functions, and ceremonies, the Executive Committee may form subcommittees of members as needed. Detailed operating guidelines for standing subcommittees and affiliated clubs shall be determined by the Executive Committee in accordance with Article XII of these Bylaws.

Article VI. Advisory Board

The Advisory Board is composed of professionals, academics, community leaders, and other interested individuals invited to support the Society's mission and programs. Advisory Board members serve in a non-voting, consultative capacity and may offer suggestions on policies and activities.

Article VII. Duties of Officers

1. President

- Shall preside at all meetings of the Society and the Executive Committee.
- Shall provide overall supervision of the Society's work, subject to the policies of the General Assembly.
- Shall cast the deciding vote in cases of a tie at Executive Committee and General Assembly meetings.
- Shall represent the Society in meetings and activities with other organizations and government bodies.
- Shall update the Society's official address upon assuming office.

2. Vice President

- Shall perform duties and exercise powers delegated by the President with advice of the Executive Committee.
- Shall assume the full duties and powers of the President in the President's absence.

3. General Secretary

- Shall send notices of all meetings, keep and read minutes, and serve as custodian of all Society records.
- Shall review and approve General Member applications on behalf of the Executive Committee.

4. Secretary

- Shall assist the General Secretary in all duties and shall serve as Acting General Secretary in the General Secretary's absence.

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5. Treasurer

- Shall be responsible for all financial transactions of the Society.
- Shall receive all income and pay all bills upon authorization of the Executive Committee.
- Shall maintain the Society's bank account(s) in the name of Far-Western Nepalese Society, Maryland, USA.
- Shall keep accurate accounts of all funds received and disbursed, and shall submit a written financial report at the annual meeting and at intervals as required.
- The Society's books shall be audited annually by a qualified accounting firm or CPA selected by the Executive Committee.
- All checks and financial instruments must be co-signed by the Treasurer and the President or General Secretary.
- The Treasurer's single-expenditure authority is limited to \$500.00, subject to change by majority vote of the Executive Committee. Any expenditure exceeding this limit requires prior Executive Committee approval.

6. Members at Large (Board of Directors)

- Shall carry out responsibilities assigned by the Executive Committee and support the Society's programs and activities.

Article VIII. Financial Management

The Society maintains its own bank account(s) in the name of "Far-Western Nepalese Society, Maryland, USA." All funds shall be deposited into the Society's official account(s) and used exclusively for the furtherance of the Society's stated purposes.

The Executive Committee is authorized to open, close, or change banking institutions by majority vote, provided that the President and Treasurer are designated as authorized signatories at all times. No individual officer or member shall commingle Society funds with personal or other funds. A financial statement shall be presented to the General Assembly at each annual meeting.

Article IX. General Assembly

- The General Assembly shall meet at least once per year in Maryland, convened by the Executive Committee. All dues-paying members in good standing are voting members. At least four (4) weeks' advance notice shall be provided.

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- The annual meeting is held to approve general policies, review and approve the financial statements of the Society, and address any other business properly presented.
- The General Assembly is the highest governing authority of the Society and shall approve the programs and policies of FWNS-MD.
- A quorum shall consist of one-third of the current membership in good standing. If a meeting is adjourned for lack of a quorum, it shall be rescheduled within thirty (30) days, at which rescheduled meeting the previously present members shall constitute a quorum. Any decisions may be made by a simple majority of the members present.
- Elections of the Executive Committee shall be held at the annual General Assembly every two (2) years.
- Special meetings of the General Assembly may be called by the President or the Executive Committee, or upon written request of one-fourth of the general membership, with the stated purpose specified in the call. No other business shall be transacted at a special meeting.
- Notice of regular and special meetings may be given by email, text message, social media, the FWNS-MD website, or local Nepali community media. Notice shall be provided at least four (4) weeks in advance for annual meetings and at least two (2) weeks in advance for special meetings.

Article X. Nominations and Elections

- The Executive Committee's term shall be two (2) years. Terms shall end in the month of June every two years following the election of a new Executive Committee. The Executive Committee may extend the term and election date by up to ninety (90) days if necessary.
- The President shall, in consultation with the Executive Committee, set an election date prior to expiration of the current term. An Election Committee of up to seven (7) members shall be appointed at least two (2) months prior to the election date, with one member designated as Chair.
- Only Life Members (Individual or Couple) are eligible to run as candidates for any elected position on the Executive Committee, subject to the tenure requirements described in Article IV.
- For the five (5) core officer positions — President, Vice President, General Secretary, Secretary, and Treasurer — candidates must have held Life Member status for at least one (1) year at the time of the election, in addition to the one (1) year General Membership prerequisite, totaling a minimum of two (2) years of active involvement with FWNS-MD.

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- For at-large Board of Directors positions, Life Member status at the time of candidacy filing is sufficient, with no additional tenure requirement beyond the Life Membership eligibility criteria.
- All dues-paying members (General and Life) in good standing are eligible to vote. General Members must have renewed or applied for membership at least sixty (60) days prior to the election date. Life Members may vote in any election regardless of renewal date.
- All voters must present a valid photo ID matching the voter list. Voters must be residents of the State of Maryland.
- Candidacies shall be nominated by two (2) members — one nominating and one seconding. A simple majority of votes cast shall elect a candidate. Where there is only one candidate for a position, election may be conducted by voice vote or acclamation.

Election Nomination Fees

Nomination fees for candidates running in Executive Committee elections shall be determined by the currently serving Executive Committee prior to each election cycle. The serving Executive Committee shall announce the nomination fee schedule at least sixty (60) days before the election date. These fees are separate from membership dues and are non-refundable. All collected nomination fees shall be deposited into the Society's official account and used to offset election administration costs.

Article XI. Termination of Position

An executive officer or member of the Executive Committee shall be removed from his/her/their position under the following circumstances:

- **Resignation:** Must be submitted in writing to the Executive Committee or the President.
- **Death.**
- **Unexcused Absence:** Failure to attend three (3) consecutive Executive Committee meetings without a valid written explanation submitted to the President shall result in automatic loss of position.
- **Vote of No Confidence:** A motion must be submitted by one-fourth of the membership. A special General Assembly shall be called with at least thirty (30) days' notice specifying the agenda, and the motion must be approved by a majority of members present.

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Vacancies

In the event of a vacancy in the office of President, the Vice President shall assume presidential responsibilities until a special General Assembly elects a new President within sixty (60) days. For all other vacant positions, the Executive Committee may appoint a qualified at-large member to the vacant position until the next general election.

Article XII. Affiliated Clubs, Teams & Subcommittees

A. Standing Committees

Standing committees shall include: Membership, Program, Public Relations, Sports & Recreation, Youth & Education, and Finance. These are appointed by the Executive Committee. Special and ad hoc committees are appointed by the President with approval of the Executive Committee. All committees report to the Executive Committee as directed by the President.

B. Affiliated Clubs and Teams

Sports teams, cultural clubs, and other groups that operate under the name of the Far-Western Nepalese Society, use the FWNS-MD name or logo, or represent the Society in any official capacity must meet the following affiliation requirements:

- **Membership Requirement:** At least two-thirds (2/3) of the active members of any affiliated club or team must be current dues-paying members of FWNS-MD in good standing.
- **Youth Exception:** For teams or clubs comprised primarily of participants under the age of eighteen (18), the membership requirement is satisfied if at least two-thirds (2/3) of the participating youth have at least one parent or legal guardian who is a current dues-paying member of FWNS-MD.
- **Registration:** All affiliated clubs and teams must formally register with the Executive Committee and be approved by majority vote. Registration shall include a roster, a designated point of contact, and acknowledgment of these Bylaws.
- **Conduct:** Affiliated clubs and teams shall conduct themselves in a manner consistent with the values and purposes of FWNS-MD. The Executive Committee reserves the right to revoke affiliation status for conduct unbecoming of the organization.

C. Operating Guidelines for Clubs and Subcommittees

Specific operating guidelines, financial support policies, participation rules, and other operational details for each affiliated club, team, or subcommittee are governed by

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separate policy documents established and maintained by the Executive Committee. The Executive Committee has full authority to create, revise, or revoke such guidelines as it deems appropriate, without requiring an amendment to these Bylaws. All such policies must remain consistent with the purposes and values of the Society.

D. Club Authorization and Dispute Resolution

The serving President of the Far-Western Nepalese Society of Maryland shall have the final authority to recognize, authorize, and regulate all clubs affiliated with FWNS-MD. In the event of any dispute regarding the affiliation status, authorization, or conduct of any affiliated club, the President shall have the power to:

- (a) Recognize and formally authorize a club as an FWNS-MD affiliated club;
- (b) Mediate and resolve any dispute involving an affiliated club;
- (c) Suspend or cancel the affiliation of any club that violates FWNS-MD Bylaws, policies, or the values of the organization.

The President's decision regarding club affiliation and disputes shall be final, subject only to appeal by a two-thirds (2/3) majority vote of the full Executive Committee within thirty (30) days of the President's decision.

Article XIII. Board of Trustees

The structure, composition, powers, and responsibilities of the Board of Trustees shall be determined by the Executive Committee and ratified by the General Assembly. Until formally constituted, its functions shall be carried out by the Executive Committee.

Article XIV. Amendments to Bylaws

These Bylaws may be amended at any annual or special General Assembly meeting, provided that: (a) the proposed amendment is circulated in writing to all members with the notice of the meeting; and (b) the amendment is approved by a two-thirds (2/3) majority of members present and voting. No amendment shall be inconsistent with the Society's Articles of Incorporation or applicable law.

Article XV. Dissolution

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The dissolution of the Society may be decided upon by a two-thirds (2/3) majority of members present and voting at a General Assembly meeting, provided that notice of the proposed dissolution has been circulated with the meeting notice. Upon dissolution, after payment of all liabilities, any remaining assets shall be distributed to one or more 501(c)(3) nonprofit organizations with purposes consistent with those of the Society, as determined by the Executive Committee and approved by the General Assembly.

CERTIFICATION OF ADOPTION

Adopted at the Annual General Meeting held on February 28, 2026

These Bylaws were duly adopted by the General Assembly of the Far-Western Nepalese Society, Maryland, USA, at the Annual General Meeting held on February 28, 2026, and supersede all prior bylaws and informal governing documents of the Society.

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